Intent Forms, Not Formulas: Natural-Language Path Planning with Guaranteed Walkable Paths

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***Abstract*— People give navigation instructions that mix a destination, prohibitions, ordered stops and soft preferences: *"go to the lab, don't go through the workshop, stop at the store room first, and stay in the corridor if you can."* Asking a large language model (LLM) for the path accepts any phrasing but guarantees nothing; translating the sentence into temporal logic gives guarantees but the formula is hard to get right and cannot express "if you can." We separate the two jobs. The LLM sees only the instruction and the region names and fills a small, readable *intent form*; it never sees the map or emits a coordinate. The form is validated, compiled into walls and cell weights, and solved by A* over (cell, waypoint-progress) states, and an independent verifier checks every path. We prove that every returned path is walkable even when the LLM misreads the instruction, and that, given a correct parse, it satisfies all hard constraints, is optimal, is never missed when one exists, and lengthens by at most a fixed factor because of soft preferences. On a benchmark of 495 instructions over 20 floor plans, using the same LLM for every method, our method is correct on 100% of inputs, an LLM$\rightarrow$ LTL$_f$ $\rightarrow$automaton planner on 88% (61% on ordered stops), and an end-to-end LLM planner produces a walkable path in 1 of 161 attempts.**

I. Introduction

A grid planner such as A* [1] takes one goal cell. A person instructing a robot gives much more: a destination, places that must not be entered, places to visit in a given order, and preferences that should be honoured only when they are cheap. Two families of methods turn such language into robot behaviour, and each falls short in a different way.

LLMs as planners. An LLM can read the map (as text) and write the path directly [2], or propose waypoints that a search connects [3]. This accepts any phrasing, but nothing guarantees that the path avoids walls or forbidden rooms, and LLMs are known to be unreliable at multi-step planning [4], [5].

LLMs as translators to formal logic. The sentence is translated into a temporal-logic formula, which an automaton-based planner then satisfies [6], [7], [8], [9]. Given the right formula, the plan is correct by construction [10]. In practice the formula is the weak point: it is hard to write correctly, it is unreadable to the user who must check it, and a Boolean formula cannot express "if you can."

We take a middle path in the spirit of LLM+P [11] and LLM-modulo planning [5]: **the LLM decides *what* the user wants; A* decides *how*.** The LLM fills a fixed, five-field intent form; everything downstream is classical and verified. Our contributions are:

1) A pipeline in which LLM output can influence the path *only* through a validated intent form, with a product-graph A* that handles prohibitions, strictly ordered waypoints and weighted soft preferences in one optimal search (Sec. IV).
2) Six guarantees with short proofs: walkability independent of the parse (T1), soundness, completeness and optimality given the parse (T2–T4), a bounded detour for soft preferences (T5), and exact correspondence of the hard part with an LTL$_f$ formula (T6) (Sec. V).
3) A benchmark of 165 instructions $\times$ 3 wordings with gold intent forms, gold LTL$_f$ formulas and solver-verified labels, and a controlled comparison with an end-to-end LLM planner and an LLM$\rightarrow$ LTL$_f$ planner using the same LLM, prompt budget and maps (Sec. VI).

II. Related Work

Language grounding for navigation. Early work grounded commands with probabilistic graphical models over spatial relations [12]. LLM-based systems now select skills [13], write robot programs [14], [15], or plan in text. None of these give guarantees on the geometric path.

LLMs as path planners. PPNL [2] benchmarks LLMs that read a grid and output a path, and finds frequent invalid moves on larger grids; our M1 baseline follows this setting. LLM-A* [3] lets the LLM propose intermediate waypoints that A* connects, improving efficiency; the path is walkable, but the LLM still reasons about coordinates and constraints such as prohibitions or ordering are not guaranteed.

LLMs as translators to temporal logic. Lang2LTL [6], NL2LTL [7], nl2spec [8] and AutoTAMP [9] translate language into LTL or signal temporal logic, which is then planned against with automata-based methods [10], [16]. Our M2 baseline follows this route with finite-trace LTL (LTL$_f$) [17] and Spot [18]. We show that, on the hard constraints, our intent form is exactly a fragment of LTL$_f$ (T6), so the comparison isolates the effect of the *target representation* the LLM must produce.

LLMs with classical planners. LLM+P [11] has the LLM write a PDDL problem for a classical planner, and the LLM-modulo view [5] argues for LLMs paired with sound external verifiers. Our work applies this idea to geometric navigation with soft preferences, with proofs specific to the grid setting.

III. Problem Setting

Map. An 8-connected grid; F is the set of free cells. Each free cell belongs to at most one named region (rooms, a

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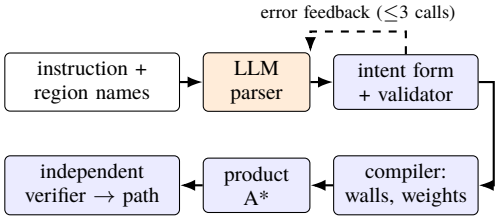


Fig. 1. Pipeline (M3). Orange: the only learned component; it sees the instruction and region names, never the map, and outputs a five-field intent form. Blue: classical, verified components.

corridor); R_r is the set of cells of region r. A diagonal step is legal only if both orthogonal neighbours are also allowed (no corner cutting). Step length $d(v,u)$ is 1 or $\sqrt{2}$.

Intent form. $I = (g, X, (w_1, \ldots, w_m), P, A)$: a goal region g, forbidden regions X, ordered waypoints w_j, preferred regions P and avoided regions A. The *sequence* is $u_1, \ldots, u_{m+1} = w_1, \ldots, w_m, g$. I is *well-formed* if all names exist on the map, the sequence has no repeats, no sequence element is forbidden, and $P \cap A = \emptyset$.

Satisfaction. Let $S_I = F \setminus \bigcup_{x \in X} R_x$. Forbidden cells are treated as walls, also for the corner rule, so a path never grazes them. Let $e_j(\pi)$ be the first index at which path π enters u_j. A path π from start s *satisfies* I if it is valid in S_I, ends in g, enters every u_j, and $e_1 < e_2 < \cdots < e_{m+1}$ (*strict ordering*: "A before B" means B is never entered before A).

Cost. Cell weight $w(u) = 0.5$ if preferred, 3 if avoided, else 1; path cost $J(\pi) = \sum_i d(v_i, v_{i+1})\, w(v_{i+1})$ and length $L(\pi) = \sum_i d(v_i, v_{i+1})$. The task is to return a minimum-cost satisfying path, or `NO_PATH` if none exists.

IV. Method

Fig. 1 shows the pipeline.

Parser. The LLM receives the instruction, the list of region names and two worked examples, and returns JSON, e.g.

```
{goal: lab, forbidden: [workshop],
waypoints: [store_room], prefer: [corridor], avoid: []}
```

The form is validated against the well-formedness rules; on failure the error is fed back, for at most three calls. The LLM never sees the grid.

Compiler. Forbidden regions become walls; preferred cells get weight 0.5, avoided cells 3, others 1.

Product-graph A*. A state is (v, k): cell v after entering the first k sequence elements in order. From (v, k) any legal step in S_I to u is allowed *unless* u lies in an element not yet due, $u_{k+2}, \ldots, u_{m+1}$; entering u_{k+1} increments k. Goal states are $(v, m+1)$ with $v \in R_g$; step cost is $d(v,u)\, w(u)$. The heuristic is $h(v) = w_{\min} \cdot \mathrm{oct}(v, R_g)$, the octile distance to the nearest goal cell scaled by the smallest weight of any allowed cell. The scaling is essential: with preferred cells at weight 0.5, unscaled octile distance overestimates and A* can return a suboptimal path. A start inside a forbidden region or inside a later sequence element returns `NO_PATH` with a reason.

Verifier. A separate module, sharing no code with the planner, re-checks every returned path (legal moves, no forbidden cell, strict order, ends in goal) and recomputes its cost. A failure raises an exception; it is never returned silently.

V. Guarantees

We state the results; full proofs are in the project repository. Two facts drive them. *(F1)* h is consistent: octile distance obeys the triangle inequality and every step costs at least $w_{\min}\, d(v,u)$. *(F2)* The counter is honest and complete: along any planner path k counts the elements entered, in order; and every satisfying path, annotated with this count, is a planner path of the same cost.

T1 (walkability, unconditional). For every well-formed intent form, even one that misreads the instruction, the output is `NO_PATH` or a physically valid path. *Proof:* every planner step is legal in $S_I \subseteq F$. The LLM can only remove cells, change positive weights, or choose regions to visit; none adds a step through a wall. □

T2–T4 (soundness, completeness, optimality). Every returned path satisfies I; `NO_PATH` is returned only if no satisfying path exists; and the returned path has minimum cost J. *Proof:* T2 from F2. T3: by F2 a goal state is reachable, and the state space is finite. T4: A* with a consistent heuristic and positive costs is optimal [1], and by F2 no satisfying path is cheaper. □

T5 (bounded detour). Let L^* be the shortest length of a path satisfying the hard part of I. Then $L(\hat{\pi}) \le \frac{w_{\max}}{w_{\min}} L^* \le 6L^*$; with preferences only, $\le 2L^*$. *Proof:* preferences change only weights, so the satisfying paths are the same; $w_{\min} L(\hat{\pi}) \le J(\hat{\pi}) \le J(\pi_{L^*}) \le w_{\max} L^*$ by T4. □

T5 is the formal content of "if you can": a preference can never cause an unbounded detour and never changes whether a path exists.

T6 (LTL_f correspondence). Define $\psi_{m+1} = \mathbf{F}(g \wedge \mathit{last})$, $\psi_j = \neg(u_{j+1} \vee \cdots \vee u_{m+1})\, \mathbf{U}\, (u_j \wedge \psi_{j+1})$ and $\varphi_I = \mathbf{G} \neg \bigvee_{x \in X} x \wedge \psi_1$. On a *corner-separated* map (no physically legal diagonal step grazes a region without entering it), a valid path satisfies the hard part of I iff its trace of region labels satisfies φ_I. All our maps are corner-separated (checked automatically). T6 provides the gold formulas for the benchmark and shows that, on hard constraints, the intent form and the LTL_f route have the same expressive power on our instructions; differences between M2 and M3 are therefore due to translation.

From proofs to code. Property-based tests [20] check T1–T5 on 1000 random grids per property against an independent NetworkX [21] product-graph solver, and in the evaluation the runtime verifier rejected 0 of the 850 paths our pipeline returned.

VI. Evaluation

A. Benchmark

Maps. 20 procedurally generated 40×40 floor plans (6 easy, 7 medium, 7 hard) with rooms, one main corridor and 1-cell doorways, plus 10 15×15 plans. Every cell's region is known exactly.

TABLE I

CORRECTNESS PER CATEGORY ON THE 40×40 BENCHMARK (M2, M3: $n = 495$; M0, M1: $n = 165$). BRACKETS: WILSON 95% CI.

Method	plain	proh.	stop	order	soft	infeas.	all
M0	100	0	10	0	100	0	35 [28–43]
M1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0 [0–2]
M2	100	100	93	61	83	100	88 [85–91]
M3	**100**	**100**	**100**	**100**	**100**	**100**	**100** [99–100]
M2-oracle	100	100	100	100	100	100	100
M3-oracle	100	100	100	100	100	100	100

Instructions. 165 instructions in six categories: plain (20), prohibition (35), stop (30), ordering (30), soft (35) and infeasible (15); 135 are templated and 30 are hand-written in deliberately messy phrasing. Each has three wordings (495 inputs), a gold intent form, a gold LTL$_f$ formula (from T6) and machine-checkable constraints. Feasibility labels and optimal costs come from an independent NetworkX solver, never from our planner. Constraints are sampled so that they matter: every prohibition changes the optimal route, and every soft instruction is one where honouring the preference changes the route. A further 20 instructions use the 15×15 maps.

B. Methods

- **M0** Plain A* to the goal, ignoring constraints (floor).
- **M1** End-to-end LLM planner: the LLM sees the ASCII map and writes the coordinate sequence, following the PPNL setting [2].
- **M2** LLM$\rightarrow$ LTL$_f$ $\rightarrow$automaton planner, following the NL-to-LTL line [6], [7], [8]: the LLM writes an LTL$_f$ formula over region names, Spot [18] builds a DFA, and we search the product of the DFA with the grid (same moves as M3).
- **M3** Ours.

Ablations: M2-/M3-oracle (gold formula / gold intent form), M2-harden (soft "avoid" written as a prohibition), M3-chain (waypoints chained with separate A* searches). M1–M3 use the same LLM (Gemini `gemini-3.5-flash-lite` [19], temperature 0), the same region-name legend and the same budget of at most three calls with error feedback. M2 and M3 run on all three wordings; M1 on the first, as its failure mode is walkability. All LLM answers are cached, so every number reproduces without API access.

Metrics. *Correct*: all hard constraints satisfied on a feasible instruction, or `NO_PATH` on an infeasible one. We report Wilson 95% intervals [22], exact paired McNemar tests [23], and bootstrap intervals for cost ratios.

C. Results

Overall. Table I and Fig. 2 summarise correctness. M3 is correct on all 495 inputs. M2 is correct on 88%; its losses concentrate on ordering (61%) and soft instructions (83%). With gold inputs both planners are perfect, so all of M2's loss is in translation, as T6 predicts. Paired McNemar test, M3 vs. M2 on the same 495 inputs: 59 inputs only M3 got right and 0 only M2 ($p = 3.5 \cdot 10^{-18}$; ordering $p = 5.8 \cdot 10^{-11}$, soft $p = 7.6 \cdot 10^{-6}$).

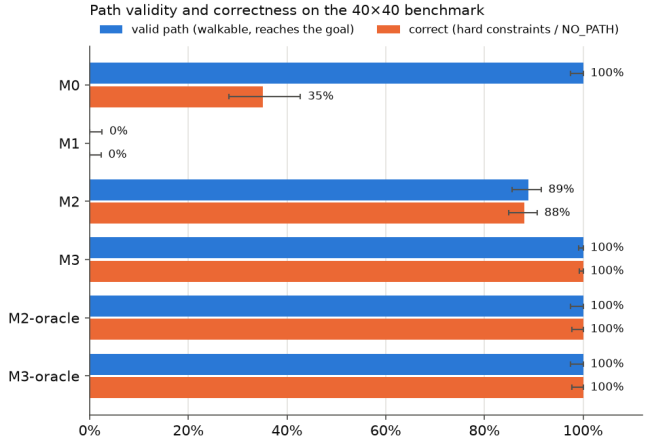


Fig. 2. Valid paths on feasible instructions and overall correctness, with Wilson 95% intervals.

TABLE II

TRANSLATION QUALITY: INTENT FORM (M3) VS. LTL$_f$ FORMULA (M2).

	M3 intent form	M2 LTL$_f$
Matches gold (Spot equiv. for M2)	**100%**	56% [52–61]
Same reading for all 3 wordings	**100%**	30% [23–37]
Correct on hand-written inputs	**90/90**	78/90
No valid output in 3 calls	0%	0%
Mean LLM calls	1.00	1.01

End-to-end LLM planning fails on walkability. Of M1's 161 returned paths, 160 are physically invalid (and all 20 on the 15×15 maps); 88% of runs step through a wall or forbidden cell, often jumping across the map, and on every infeasible instruction M1 invented a path (Fig. 3). M2 and M3 never return an invalid path. The failure is structural, not a matter of prompt tuning: coordinate-level output gives the model thousands of chances to make an illegal move.

Intent forms are easier to produce than formulas. Table II: the LLM's intent forms match the gold form on every input, while only 56% of its LTL$_f$ formulas are equivalent to the gold formula, and only 30% of instructions get the same formula for all three wordings. M2's formulas are syntactically valid but often semantically wrong. Many errors are harmless on the given map (157 runs were correct despite a non-equivalent formula), but 58 changed the path. The typical mistake on ordering is the "next" operator, which forces the robot to *start* in the first waypoint, e.g. `stairwell & X(workshop & X F(store_room & last))`, or omitting the clause that keeps the goal unvisited before earlier waypoints.

Only the intent form trades off. A Boolean formula can only ignore a preference or turn it into a rule. Table III and Fig. 4: M3 nearly doubles the time spent in the preferred corridor and mostly stays out of avoided rooms, at an average of 9% extra length (maximum 23%), far inside the T5 bound of $2\times$ for preferences (Fig. 5). Hardening "avoid if you can"



Fig. 3. The same prohibition instruction. Left: the end-to-end LLM (M1) writes a path that crosses walls. Right: M3's path, walkable by construction (T1).

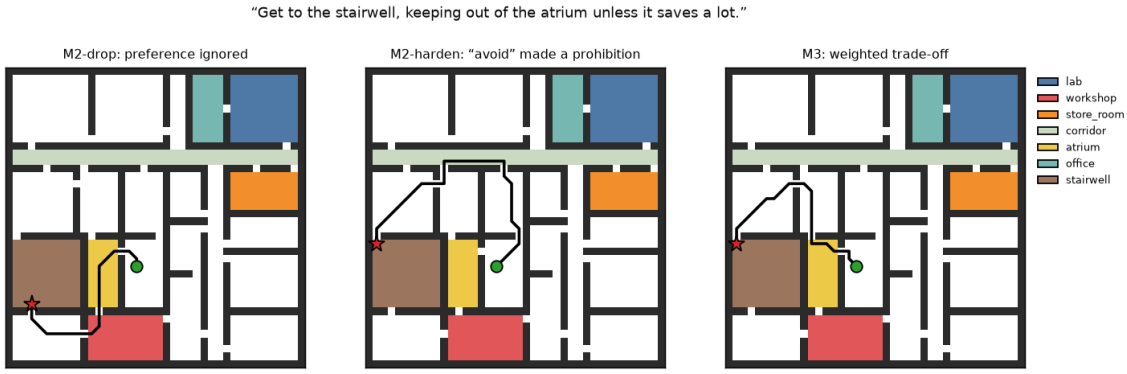


Fig. 4. A soft "avoid" instruction. Ignoring the preference (left) walks through the avoided room; hardening it (middle) forces a long detour; M3 (right) trades off.

TABLE III

SOFT-PREFERENCE INSTRUCTIONS: SHARE OF PATH LENGTH IN THE PREFERRED CORRIDOR AND IN THE AVOIDED ROOM, AND LENGTH RELATIVE TO M3.

Method	in preferred	in avoided	length / M3
M2-drop (ignored)	27%	16%	0.92
M2-harden (prohibited)	27%	0%	0.96 (max 1.36)
M2 (LLM's encoding)	28%	12%	0.89
M3	**51%**	**2%**	1.00

removes the avoided room but costs up to 36% more length than M3 on the same instruction.

Infeasibility. On the 15 infeasible instructions (goal reachable only through a forbidden room, or a waypoint reachable only through the goal), M2 and M3 answered `NO_PATH` on every wording; by T3 this is a certificate of impossibility for the parsed form. M1 invented a path every time; M0 ignores the constraint.

Ablations. M3's paths cost exactly the reference optimum (ratio 1.000); M2 plans without weights, so its correct paths cost 2.2% more under the instruction's preferences. Chaining waypoints with separate searches is strictly worse on 8% of waypoint instructions (up to 5.4% more cost); the product search is never worse. M3-oracle expands 744 states on average vs. 1,127 for the automaton planner, which has no heuristic. On the 15×15 maps the picture is the same: M1 0%, M2 88%, M3 100%.

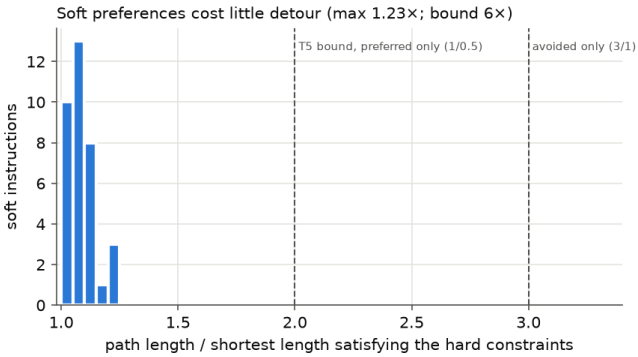


Fig. 5. Length of M3's soft-preference paths relative to the shortest path satisfying the hard constraints, against the T5 bounds.

VII. LIMITATIONS

The parser is not guaranteed. T2–T5 hold for the parsed form; the parse itself is measured, not proved. Our benchmark is synthetic: region names are given, sentences are short, and most instructions are templated. Harder language will lower M3's (and M2's) accuracy; T1 still keeps every path

walkable, and errors remain visible in a form the user can read. **Scope of comparison.** M1 and M2 are our implementations of the end-to-end and NL-to-LTL paradigms with a shared LLM and prompt budget, not the original systems; we have not yet compared against hybrid planners such as LLM-A* [3] or LLM+P [11]. All results use one LLM at temperature 0. **Expressiveness.** The intent form covers goals, prohibitions, ordered stops and region preferences; it does not express repetition, conditionals or metric constraints, which full LTL can. **Abstraction.** Walkability is on an 8-connected grid without corner cutting; robot geometry and dynamics are out of scope.

VIII. Conclusion and Future Work

Restricting the LLM to a small, validated intent form, and leaving geometry to a verified product-graph A*, gives paths that are always walkable, provably correct and optimal for the parsed instruction, and able to honour soft preferences with a bounded cost. On our benchmark the LLM produced correct intent forms far more reliably than correct temporal-logic formulas for the same instructions. Future work is to compare against published hybrid LLM planners (LLM-A*, LLM+P) and the original NL-to-LTL systems, to evaluate on real building maps and free-form human instructions, to extend the form with spatial relations and repetition, and to deploy the planner on a mobile robot.

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